SAMAJWADI PARTY

AKHILESH'S GOOD FIGHT

A YEAR OR TWO short of their 50th birthdays, both Yogi Adityanath and Akhilesh Yadav represent the younger generation of Indian politicians poised to inherit the mantle of their respective parties in the country. This round has gone to the 49-year-old Yogi Adityanath, giving him a second consecutive shot at chief ministership while denying Akhilesh a second stint. The Samajwadi Party scion appears to have been premature in his hope for his party's resurgence, but its electoral performance is not entirely a lost cause in the manner of the Congress and Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party seem to be after Election 2022.

The SP tally of 111 may have been significantly off the 202 mark needed for a majority in the 403-member Vidhan Sabha, but it did manage to deprive the BJP the added bombast of having gone '300 *ke paar*'. The saffron no doubt stole a march in the election, but by a significantly reduced majority from its 2017 tally—255 this time to 312 in the previous electoral outing. SP, on the other hand, saw an impressive improvement in its tally over 2017—adding 64 seats to the 47 seats it won last time. Its vote share has seen a tremendous jump of 10 percentage points, going up from 21.8 per cent in 2017 to 32.1 per cent this election.

Akhilesh's greatest achievement in Election 2022, however, was to have converted the contest into a bipolar one, tying up with smaller parties to give a good fight to the BJP. The loss now will give the party a chance to re-examine its strategy, to see where it went wrong, and to build on its strengths. Its performance will also enable it to function as a strong opposition in the state assembly. Says a senior SP functionary, on the condition of anonymity, "We may have missed a big opportunity to defeat the BJP, but we have to take a relook at our own weaknesses and the reason behind our loss in seats we were fully confident of winning. This election also gives us hope that the people's trust in the Samajwadi Party is on the rise and of Akhilesh Yadav emerging as the primary challenger for the BJP in UP."

While the SP may not have won enough seats in western UP, they did manage to sweep several districts. In Purvanchal, the party won all seats in Azamgarh district, which Akhilesh currently represents in Parliament. All of Ghazipur's seven seats went to SP too, as did the three seats in Kaushambi. The SP-Apna Dal (K) alliance candidate Pallavi Patel proved to be a giant killer, as she defeated outgoing deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya by 7,337 votes in Sirathu. In Ambedkar Nagar and Etawah as well, all the seats went the SP way.

SP's biggest disappointment came from western UP, where Jayant Chaudhary's Rashtriya Lok Dal managed to make its presence felt among the Jats and Muslims in the region, but could not convert it into votes. "*Jaaton ka saath nahin mila* (we didn't get Jat support)," rues an SP functionary. The RLD won only 8 out of 33 seats in which they fielded candidates.

Nor did the influx of non-Yadav OBC leaders such as Swami Prasad Maurya, Dharam Singh Saini and Dara Singh Chauhan pay any electoral dividends.



REACHING OUT
Akhilesh receives a warm welcome from supporters in Rae Bareli